

Student Quickstart

First-hour setup for macOS, Windows, and Linux

Student Quickstart : First-Hour Setup

This printable guide is for students who want the shortest path to a working local setup before going deeper into the course.

1. Goal for your first hour

By the end of your first hour, you should be able to:

- clone the repo
- create your `.env` file
- start Docker Compose
- open n8n at `http://localhost:5678`
- import the core workflows
- import the Postman collection

You do **not** need to complete the entire M-Pesa flow in the first hour.

2. Supported operating systems

This course officially supports:

- **macOS**
- **Windows**
- **Linux**

Use the matching guide in `docs/` :

- `platform-setup-macos.md`
 - `platform-setup-windows.md`
 - `platform-setup-linux.md`
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3. Install these first

- Git
- Docker
- Postman

- A browser
-

4. Clone the repo

```
git clone https://github.com/<your-org-or-user>/<your-private-repo>.git
cd n8n-mpesa-course-consumer
```

5. Create your environment file

macOS / Linux

```
cd docker
cp .env.example .env
```

Windows PowerShell

```
cd docker
Copy-Item .env.example .env
```

At minimum, fill in:

- N8N_BASIC_AUTH_USER
 - N8N_BASIC_AUTH_PASSWORD
 - N8N_ENCRYPTION_KEY
 - MPESA_CONSUMER_KEY
 - MPESA_CONSUMER_SECRET
 - MPESA_SHORTCODE
 - MPESA_PASSKEY
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6. Start the stack

```
docker compose up -d
```

Check status:

```
docker compose ps
```

7. Open n8n

Open:

```
http://localhost:5678
```

Then:

1. log in with the basic auth credentials from `.env`
 2. create your n8n owner account
 3. reach the editor
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8. Import the four core workflows

Import in this order:

1. `workflows/01-mpesa-auth.json`
 2. `workflows/02-stk-push.json`
 3. `workflows/03-stk-callback.json`
 4. `workflows/04-reconciliation.json`
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9. Import the Postman collection

Use:

- `postman/mpesa-n8n.postman_collection.json`

Set:

```
n8n_base_url = http://localhost:5678
```

Then fill in your Daraja sandbox variables.

10. If something breaks

Go here next:

- `../START-HERE.md`
 - `troubleshooting.md`
 - your OS-specific setup guide
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11. First success milestone

You are in a good place if these are true:

- ☐ Docker works
- ☐ n8n opens locally
- ☐ Postman opens
- ☐ the core workflows import cleanly
- ☐ you know where the callback URL will come from later